



From Side Hustle to Storefront

Lowering the barrier for college students to start
buying and selling with their peers between classes

Northwestern University
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Introduction

As entrepreneurship becomes increasingly visible within Gen Z culture, more and more students are exploring ways to turn their creativity and skills into income. In fact, nearly $\frac{2}{3}$ of 18 to 25 year olds have started or plan to start a side hustle as an additional form of income (Intuit). From clothing resale and handmade products to content creation, digital commerce has made entrepreneurship feel more accessible than ever before. 80% of Gen Z business owners started their business online or had a mobile component (Intuit). Simultaneously, the rapid rise of AI tools has transformed how users approach ideation, marketing, as well as business operations. However, while interest in entrepreneurship continues to grow, many student entrepreneurs still struggle to take the first step.

Current e-commerce platforms are often designed for users who already possess confidence, technical knowledge, or a fully developed business idea. For first-time student sellers, the process can instead feel overwhelming and intimidating. The effort required to create a storefront, manage logistics, understand shipping, and navigate other nuances through unfamiliar tools creates friction before students ever begin selling. Many students instead turn toward informal peer-to-peer selling methods through social media, group chats, or campus networks because these alternatives feel more approachable.

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This paper explores how e-commerce platforms can utilize AI to better engage Gen Z entrepreneurs by lowering the barrier to entry for student sellers and creating a more guided, intuitive, and supportive onboarding experience. Guided by the question, “How might we lower the barrier to entry for student entrepreneurs by creating a more guided and intuitive selling experience?”, our research focused on designing solutions that feel approachable and capable of empowering more students to see themselves as entrepreneurs.

As college students and members of Gen Z ourselves, our team brings both personal insight and design-oriented research experience to this topic. Through survey research with 31 college students, user testing sessions with 15 participants, five in-person interviews, and analysis of current e-commerce onboarding experiences, we identified a consistent gap between student interest in entrepreneurship and the existing systems designed to support it. Students do not lack ambition or creativity. Rather, they often lack confidence, guidance, and accessible pathways into selling online.

In response, we propose a lightweight, campus-centered marketplace experience designed to make entrepreneurship feel more achievable for first-time sellers. By combining AI-assisted guidance, simplified storefront creation, and trusted student communities, this strategy reimagines how e-commerce platforms can cultivate the next generation of entrepreneurs while meeting Gen Z users where they already are.

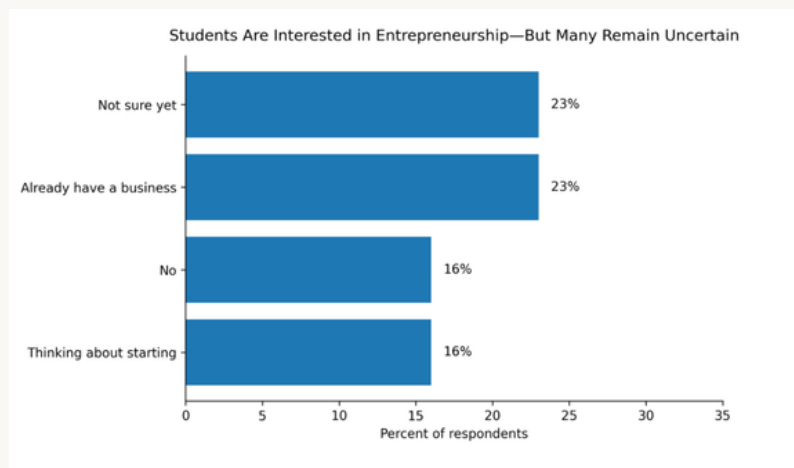
Research Insights and Prototype Validation

To better understand how college students experience entrepreneurship, our team conducted survey research with more than 30 college students, user testing sessions with 15 participants, and five in-person interviews to explore the barriers students face when moving from an initial business idea to launching an online storefront. In addition to primary research, we examined onboarding benchmarks and the current mobile and desktop experience to understand where users disengage and what contributes to early drop-off.

Across research methods, one pattern emerged consistently: students are highly interested in entrepreneurship, but uncertainty, complexity, and lack of guidance prevent many from taking action. While students were excited by the possibility of launching a business, many struggled to envision a realistic starting point. These findings shaped both the problem we chose to solve and the direction of our prototype.

a. Students and Entrepreneurship

One of the clearest insights from our initial research was that students are interested in entrepreneurship but often remain in an exploratory stage. Among survey respondents, only 23% (7 of 31) reported already having a business, while 16% (5 of 31) were considering starting one and another 23% (7 of 31) reported feeling unsure. Rather than actively building businesses, many participants existed in what we identified as a “thinking about it” phase.



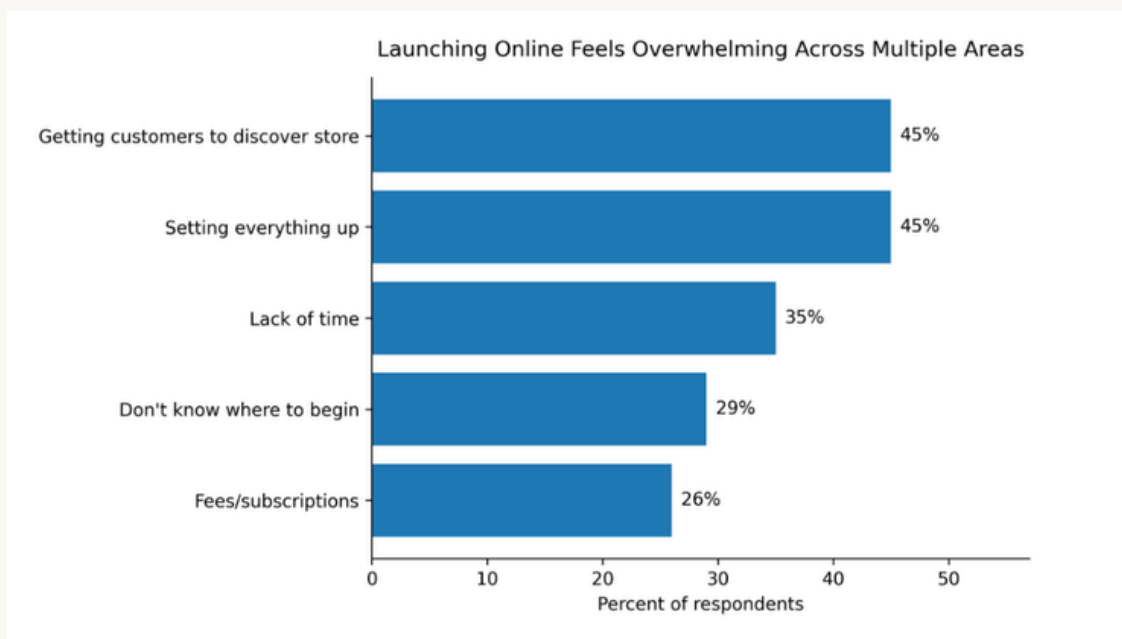
Follow up interviews reinforced this uncertainty. Participants expressed hesitation around not knowing what to sell, where to begin, or whether entrepreneurship was realistic for them. One participant explained that they only sold things they already owned, such as furniture or apartment items, and struggled to imagine what kind of business they would realistically start. Another participant wanted to start a website for her new business but was worried that she would not be able to create a website by herself. For many students, entrepreneurship felt exciting in theory but intimidating in practice.

These findings revealed an important gap in the existing eCommerce experience: platforms frequently assume users arrive with confidence, technical understanding, or a clear business direction. However, first-time student entrepreneurs often need better guidance before they are ready to launch. Rather than designing for experienced sellers, our findings suggested a need for onboarding experiences that reduce ambiguity and help students feel capable of taking an achievable first step.

b. What Prevents Students From Taking Action

While students expressed enthusiasm for entrepreneurship, many described selling online as overwhelming. Survey findings revealed that setup and uncertainty, not motivation, were the strongest barriers to action. When asked what felt intimidating about selling online, the most common frustrations included setting everything up (45%, 14 responses), getting people to discover their store (45%, 14 responses), lack of time (35%, 11 responses), uncertainty around where to begin (29%, 9 responses), and costs or subscriptions (26%, 8 responses). These findings aligned closely with broader onboarding research. Industry SaaS benchmarks suggest that approximately 30–50% of users disengage during onboarding, while nearly 80% drop off within the first three days if they do not quickly experience value or progress. Nearly half of users abandon products when they fail to immediately understand how the platform benefits them.

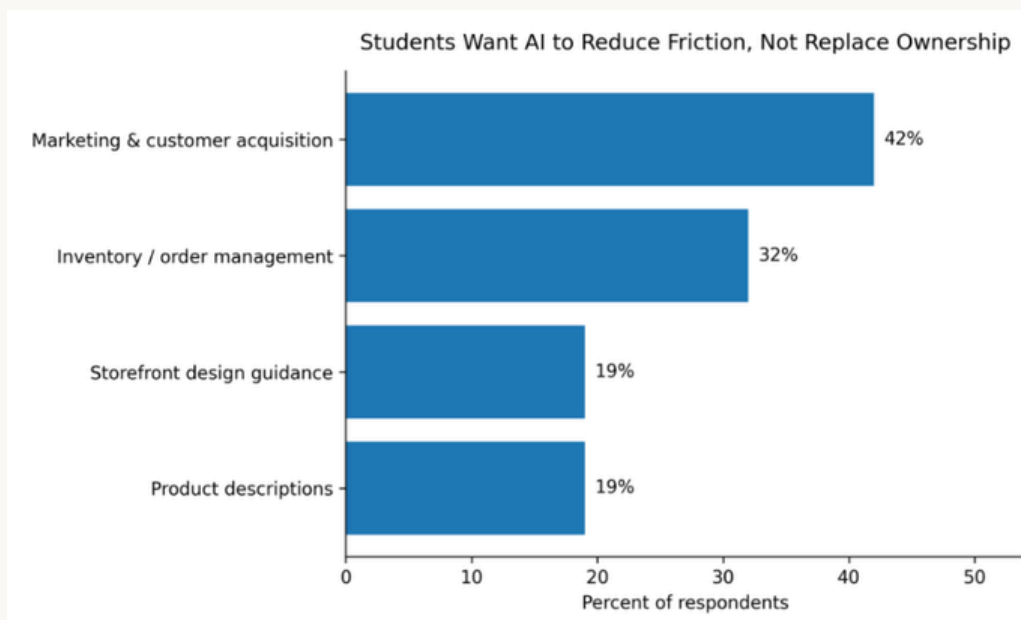
The challenge was not simply attracting students to entrepreneurship, but helping them feel momentum early in the process. For first-time entrepreneurs, onboarding becomes a psychological experience as much as a technical one. When students are faced with too many decisions, unfamiliar language, or unclear next steps, launching feels overwhelming rather than achievable. This insight directly informed our design strategy: rather than maximizing features, we focused on reducing friction and simplifying onboarding.



c. Student Thoughts on AI Integration

Survey responses also revealed strong interest in AI support, particularly when AI reduced repetitive or intimidating work. Students expressed the strongest interest in AI assistance for marketing and customer acquisition (42%, 13 responses), inventory or order management (32%, 10 responses), writing product descriptions (19%, 6 responses), and storefront design guidance (19%, 6 responses). However, user interviews revealed something more nuanced: students did not want AI to replace entrepreneurship; they wanted it to reduce uncertainty.

During prototype testing, participants described AI as exciting when it simplified decisions or provided guidance. One participant enthusiastically described the AI experience as “so cool,” while suggesting that AI could help price products based on comparable listings and market conditions. Others imagined AI helping them identify what products they could sell if they lacked ideas or confidence. Participants repeatedly framed AI as a collaborator rather than a replacement. Students wanted help launching faster, generating ideas, and reducing friction, while still maintaining creative ownership over their business. The strongest opportunity for AI in entrepreneurship may not be automation alone, but confidence-building. AI becomes valuable when it helps students feel less overwhelmed and more capable of moving from idea to action.



d. Reimagining Onboarding: Giving Entrepreneurs a Running Start

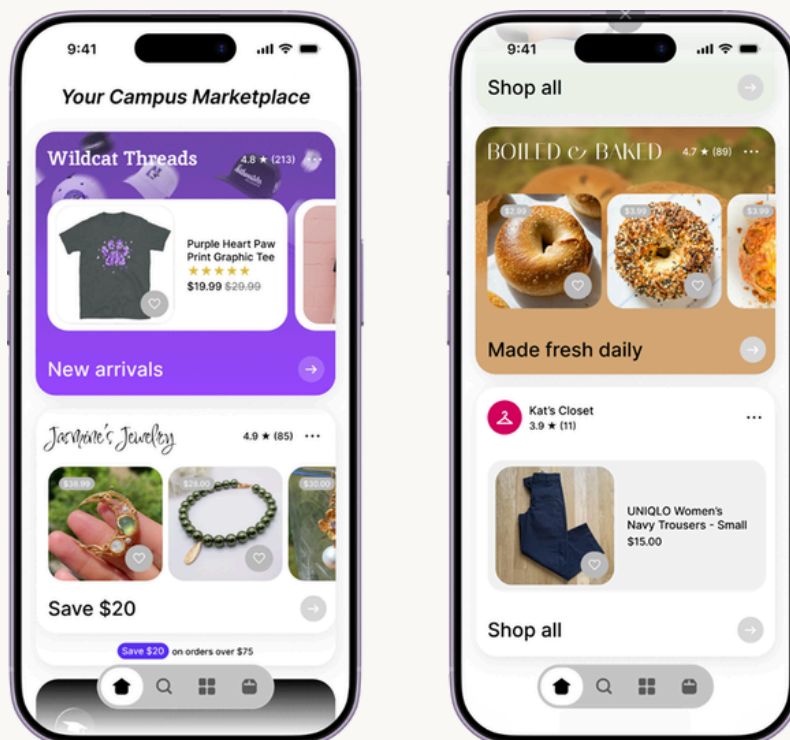
Following initial research, we developed a prototype and conducted user testing to evaluate whether our design addressed the barriers identified earlier in the process. Across testing sessions, users consistently emphasized one priority: onboarding needed to feel simple, intuitive, and fast. Participants responded positively to minimal onboarding, clear flows, and lightweight decision-making. When asked what makes a platform approachable, users highlighted intuitive onboarding, minimal steps, and simple visual organization. Several participants explicitly described the prototype as “simple” and manageable, reinforcing the importance of reducing cognitive effort during setup. Importantly, students associated speed with confidence. Rather than wanting an overwhelming number of features upfront, participants preferred experiences that quickly helped them feel capable of launching. In many cases, users interpreted quick setup as evidence that entrepreneurship itself might feel more achievable. This insight validated our earlier findings: students do not disengage because they lack ambition, but because early friction makes entrepreneurship feel intimidating.

Prototype testing also revealed that students wanted onboarding to feel flexible, supportive, and forgiving. Rather than expecting users to arrive with a fully developed business plan, participants appreciated experiences that acknowledged uncertainty. Several participants asked whether onboarding questions could be skipped if they were unsure what they planned to sell, while others suggested that AI could recommend business ideas, categories, or comparable products when users lacked direction. Rather than treating uncertainty as failure, students wanted the platform to accommodate exploration. The most successful moments in testing occurred when onboarding reduced pressure and transformed large decisions into smaller, manageable steps.

Finally, user testing revealed that students valued community visibility and professional outcomes. Participants responded positively to the idea of campus-based reach, storefront discovery, and seeing relatable peers participate in entrepreneurship. Users appreciated that the prototype made entrepreneurship feel more visible and attainable without requiring an existing audience or professional network. At the same time, participants consistently valued storefronts that looked polished and credible, reinforcing the importance of professional presentation in building confidence. Students are more motivated to engage when platforms help them feel credible and connected to a broader community.

Proposed Strategy: A Lightweight, Localized Campus Marketplace

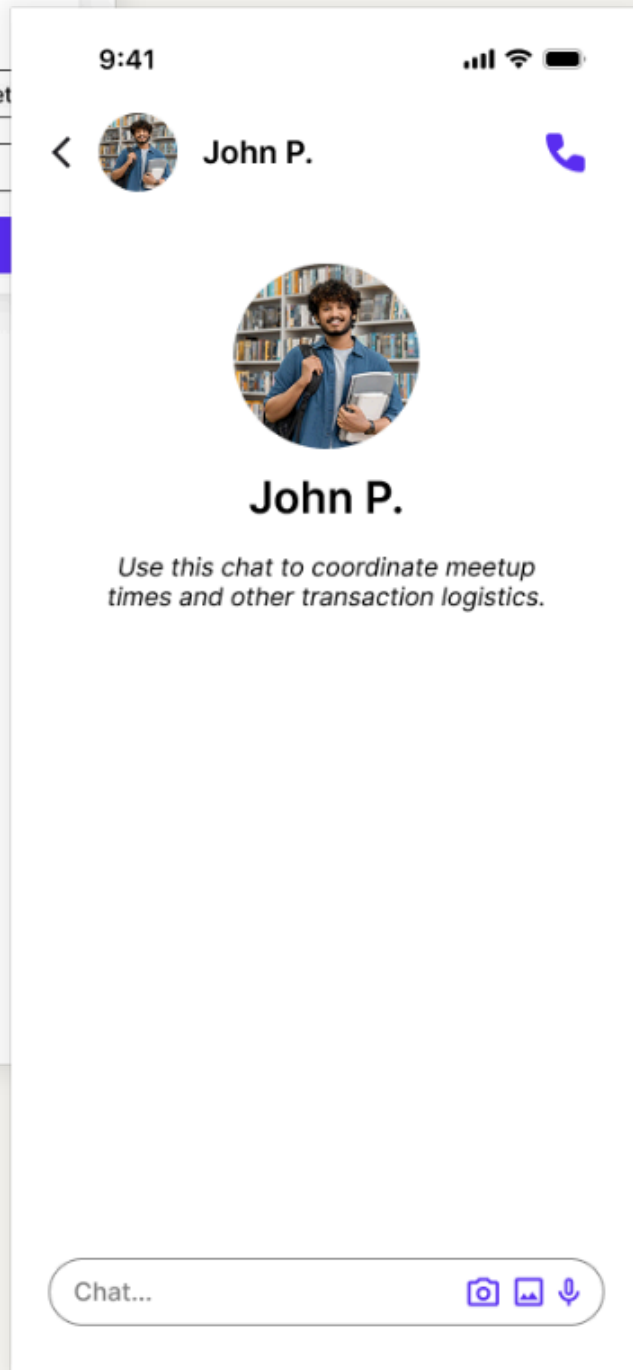
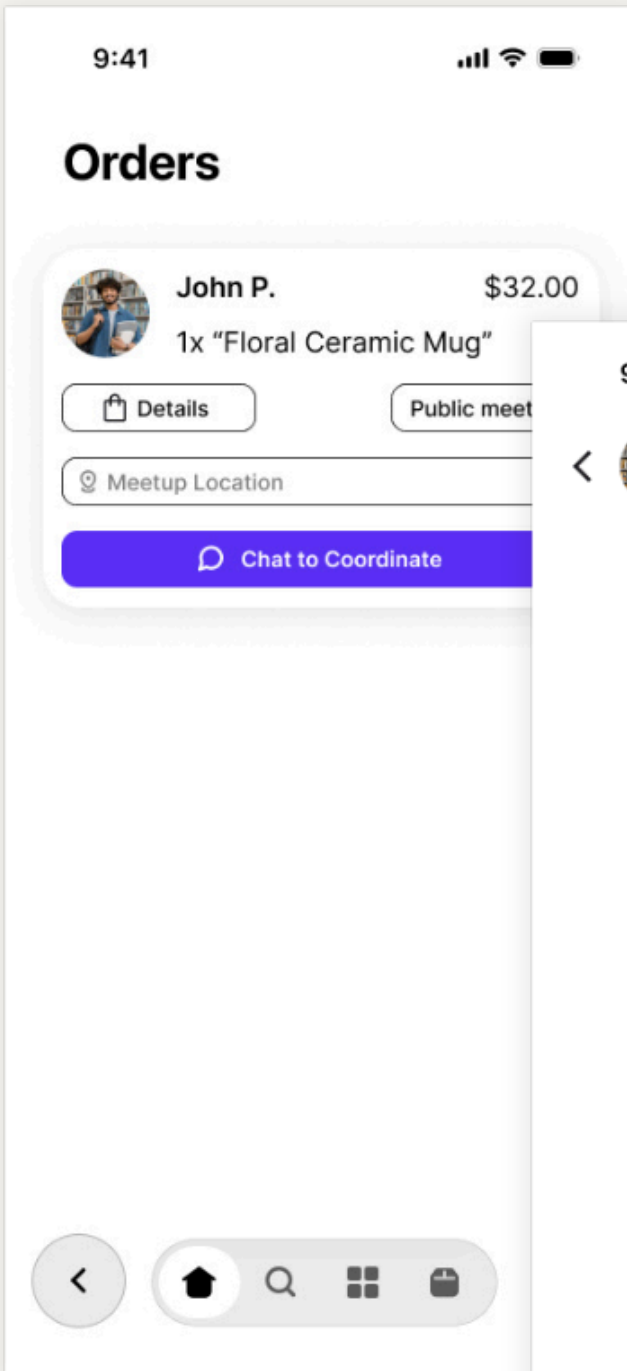
The proposed strategy introduces a mobile-first, student-centered marketplace within an existing e-commerce ecosystem, designed to lower the barrier to entry for student entrepreneurs. This solution is supported by three primary tenets: the verified student marketplace, lightweight storefront creation, and a progressive pathway to full e-commerce tools.



a. College Student-Verified Marketplace

The marketplace is specifically designed to support the behaviors and needs of university students. By only allowing access to verified college students of the same university, the platform intends to build a more trusted and community-oriented commerce experience where peers can buy and sell with one another. In a model where commerce is localized within a familiar community, listings can be tailored to student life and campus culture. Additionally, students can easily coordinate meetups, pick ups, and/or drop offs, reducing the intimidation that shipping logistics may otherwise pose.

Examples of listings include handmade goods, secondhand clothing resale, or services such as photography or hair cutting. By making commerce appear more approachable and broadly visible among peers, more students will begin to see themselves as entrepreneurs and are thus encouraged to open their own storefront.

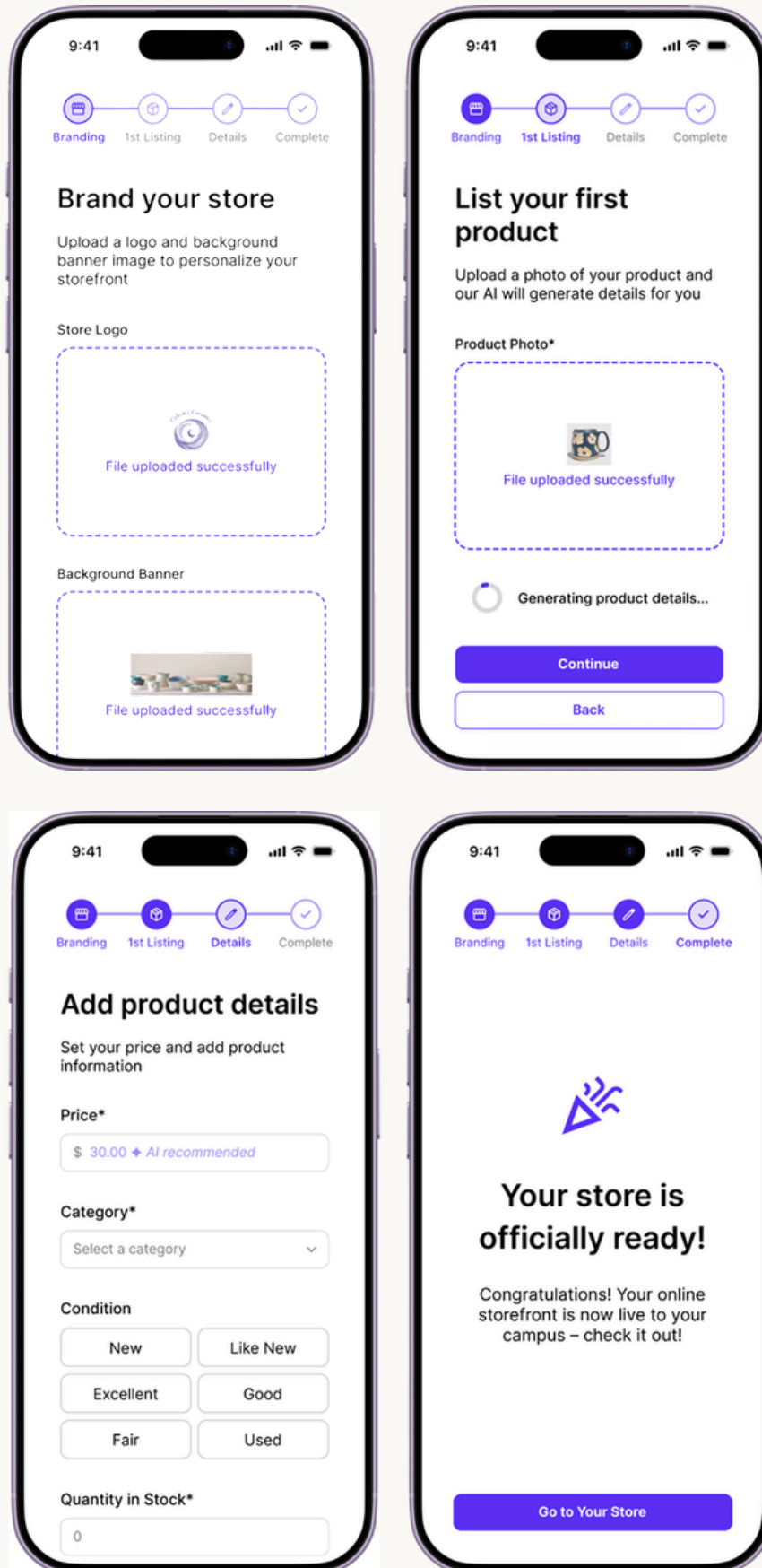


b. Lightweight Storefront Creation

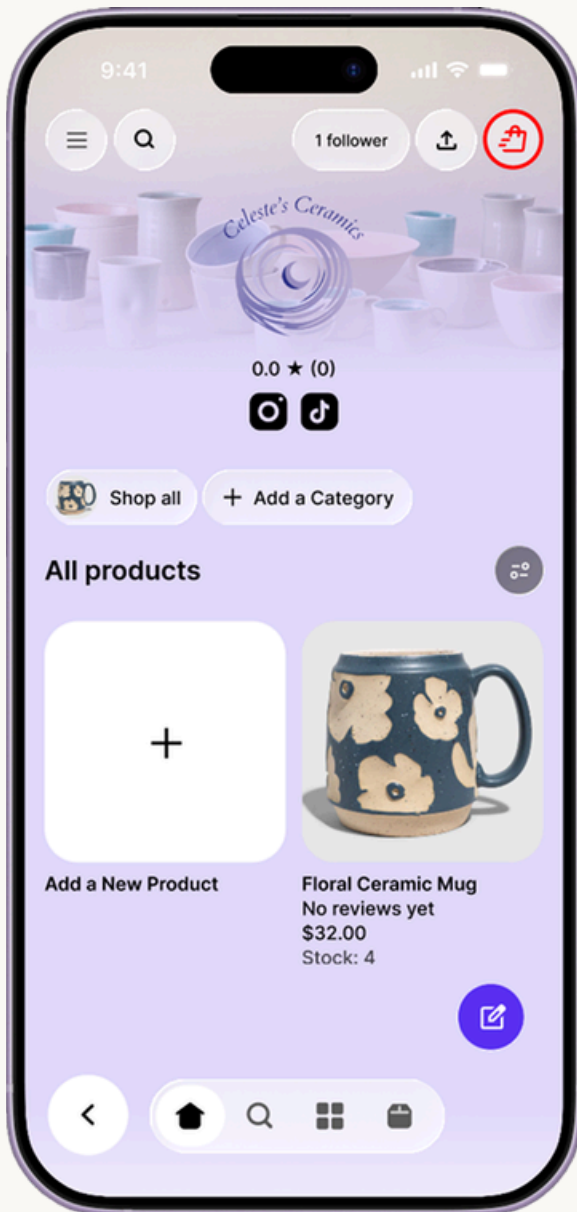
A key component of the marketplace solution is a lightweight storefront creation experience that streamlines the traditional e-commerce onboarding process, reducing logistical and psychological obstacles to entry.

ather than requiring users to immediately set up a full merchant account with access to all tools at once, students can quickly create a simplified storefront that exists within the campus marketplace ecosystem. With just three steps—branding the storefront, creating the first listing, and adding listing details—students are ready to start selling with minimal setup. This lowers the friction for first-time sellers who may not yet formally identify themselves as entrepreneurs.

This streamlined onboarding model emphasizes speed and simplicity, allowing students to move from first idea to first sale in minutes. By reaching users at an early stage of selling, the marketplace platform intercepts students before they turn towards other methods for casual entrepreneurship, such as using social media platforms or other informal campus networks.



c. Pathway to Full e-Commerce Tools



While the initial onboarding process is simplified, the campus marketplace strategy is designed to support longer-term seller growth through an accessible pathway to the full suite of e-commerce tools. Each student storefront features a dedicated icon that acts as an access point to expanded capabilities on an as-needed basis.

This pathway model benefits both users and the platform itself. Student sellers will require greater commerce infrastructure as they scale, and their initial brand familiarity and platform dependency will likely result in long-term customer retention and value for the e-commerce platform.

Technical Feasibility: Built on What Exists

The proposed solution avoids the cost and complexity of building from scratch by layering a student-centered experience on top of an existing consumer marketplace's proven infrastructure. The feature lives inside an already widely adopted shopping app, meaning no new download is required and students join a marketplace that already has reach. Student verification is frictionless given that the platform already supports institutional email verification, meaning verified student status can be added in a single step. AI-powered listing assistance, including pricing suggestions and product descriptions, can also be delivered on day one by calling the platform's existing endpoints rather than building new ones.

a. Powered by Student Networks

A campus marketplace is uniquely positioned to grow through the communities students are already part of. The go-to-market strategy unfolds in three stages: campus ambassadors build out the supply side before launch, a controlled rollout at a small cluster of schools validates the model before scaling, and targeted campaigns through club partnerships and campus tabling build local traction through networks students already trust. Beyond discovery, the campus setting also eliminates one of ecommerce's biggest friction points entirely. Buyers and sellers live and study in the same physical space, meaning transactions can be completed through simple in-person pickup at a dorm, campus building, or common area, removing shipping costs, wait times, and delivery uncertainty from the equation altogether.

The controlled rollout prioritizes large, residentially dense campuses where students are deeply embedded in campus life. Schools like University of Michigan, Dartmouth, Duke, and Notre Dame represent ideal early targets: strong on-campus cultures, high residential populations, and smaller college towns where students rely on the campus ecosystem for their daily needs. This isolation creates a natural closed loop where campus becomes the most convenient place to buy and sell.

Conclusion

The opportunity to engage Gen Z entrepreneurs is not a question of demand, but of design. Our research makes one finding unmistakable: students want to participate in entrepreneurship, but the platforms built to support them assume a level of confidence, technical fluency, and business clarity that most first-time sellers do not yet possess. With 39% of surveyed students in an exploratory "thinking about it" phase and 45% citing setup and discovery as their primary barriers, the gap between ambition and action is not a motivation problem, but an onboarding problem.

The strategy outlined in this paper—a lightweight, campus-verified marketplace layered onto an existing e-commerce ecosystem—directly addresses this gap. By combining trusted student communities, simplified four-step storefront creation, and AI that reduces uncertainty rather than replacing ownership, the proposed solution transforms entrepreneurship from an intimidating leap into an achievable first step. Critically, this approach does not ask platforms to rebuild their infrastructure. It asks them to meet students where they already are: inside familiar consumer apps, on mobile, among peers, and ready to act when friction is removed.

Conclusion cont

For e-commerce platforms evaluating where to invest next, three recommendations follow from our research. First, treat onboarding as a confidence-building experience: Ensure the flow is as easy and simple as possible, since every additional decision in the first session is a tax on a student's willingness to continue. Second, design for the exploratory majority: the largest untapped market is not experienced sellers seeking more tools, but aspiring sellers seeking permission to start. Third, solve the discovery problem by leveraging trusted community structures: Turn university networks into both a supply channel and a built-in customer base.

The platforms that win the next decade of commerce will not be the ones with the most features. They will be the ones that make a student's first sale feel inevitable. By lowering the barrier to entry today, e-commerce platforms can cultivate a pipeline of long-term sellers who grow into the full suite of commerce tools tomorrow, turning a generation of hesitant first-timers into the next generation of digital entrepreneurs.

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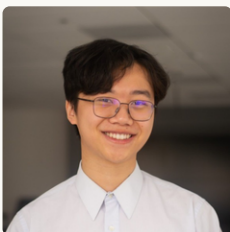
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